

Hi everyone: This is a long message that contains answers to many of your questions. Please retain it and refer to it before asking follow-up questions over next eight months. **I have added two more pages at the end that relate to various misunderstandings that I have come across this year. Please keep on reading until the end.**

While I try to respond quickly, allow for 48 hours before sending a follow up. Multiple rapid-fire follow ups slow down response time for everyone. I am traveling with limitations on computing and communication resources, do not send trivial emails such as asking me to verify your registrations. I will delete any such requests. I am attaching what have emerged as common templates for the internship and project reports. You are free to use your own style, but most of the information on cover page is essential and must be on your cover page. Please make sure that the reports are aesthetically pleasing, by choosing a good font, and consistent line spacing. We have a couple of mentors that work with us. If you are assigned one of them, their comments are not suggestions, they are mandatory modifications. If they do not provide unequivocal approval, we will not proceed with our evaluation. We will not accept any report that does not meet expected quality, even if it means you missing the graduation deadline.

1. Please apply for graduation before August 1st. The application is available through the service center website: <https://www.smu.ca/graduation/graduation-application-for-graduation.html>

2. Check the attachment to make sure you are registered for the right applied learning courses with right supervisors. 5585, 5586 are project courses (Mitacs students will be in project courses). 5587 and 5588 are internship courses. I am supervisor for all the internship courses. **Please register for FGSR9000 every semester. Make sure you have paid all your tuition. If there is a hold on your account, it may delay the graduation process. Send all the tuition queries to Neelam.**

You need to follow the steps below carefully:

- a. Make sure that you have either registered for or have completed MCDA5560 and 5580
- b. Make sure you are registered for MCDA5585/5586/5587/5588 as shown in the attached spreadsheet against your name.
- c. If the answer to b is no, you will see registration overrides given by Neelam on banner. Please direct all the questions related to registration to Neelam. Pink highlight means registration in Summer. Orange highlight means registration in Fall. You will only register for summer (pink) registrations at this time. The overrides are not registrations. You have to register for these courses yourself through banner. You need to directly enter the CRN since these are closed courses.
- d. You should have completed MCDA5510, 5520, 5530, 5540, 5560, 5570, 5580, unless any one of these courses have been explicitly exempted in the spreadsheet.
- e. **This point will come into effect in August:** After you have completed steps a, b, c, and d, make sure that you have a total of thirty credits (10 courses) labelled MCDA – either registered or completed. Neelam has conducted an audit to see which one of the classroom-based courses in the range MCDA5510 to MCDA5580 are missing. You can see them in the “Courses Missing” column. Those highlighted in red will need to be taken in Fall. I have highlighted greens as waived. **However, it is your responsibility to make sure that you have 10 MCDA courses (30 credits). Otherwise, your graduation will be delayed.**
- f. **This point will come into effect in August:** If you are banner savvy, please run degree works to see that everything is in order. Degree works does not always function properly. As long as you’re a-d is okay, do not worry. I will override degree works.

3. If you have finished your project and taken up a job with your internship work permit, you need to have an approval from me and need to be registered in 5587. Otherwise, you will be in violation of your internship work permit. Please make sure that you are in the clear.

4. Project reports for students who do not have any internship courses: The report is read by three examiners. Your supervisor, an academic examiner, and Dan Penny (for your project management documentation). Dan will be conducting more workshops on project management (PM) in August. You must attend those, otherwise, you may be found wanting on the PM documentation. In addition, we may add some industry experts to test the projects that consist of software development. Please ask your supervisor to share a sample report from one of the previous students. In the past 90% of the project reports were approved without much delay. However, we are known to ask for revisions until the project meets the program quality. We will not compromise quality to help you meet the graduation deadline. We expect a minimum of 600

hours of technical work and another 120 hours for report writing and approval process. 600 hours does not mean you watching the clock tick for that many hours. Your work has to justify the 600 hours spent on it.

5. Internship reports: Please note that the 600-hour guideline only applies to project courses. We expect three months of full-time employment (35-40 hours/week) for one internship course. There are no hours allocated for writing an internship report. A minimal template consists of half page of description of your work for every week. It is a good idea to submit bi-weekly reports, so you are not stressed at the end and also have some preliminary feedback from me. Introduction (two-three pages) consisting of the description of company, your team, and your responsibilities. Summary and conclusions (one-two pages): What you learned and its relationship to the goals of CDA. For one internship course, we typically expect three months of full-time work. Internship report needs to be approved by your industry supervisor and I need an email to the effect "The report is an accurate reflection of student's work during the internship period, and student's performance was completely satisfactory." I will then review the report and submit your grade(s).

6. Project reports for students who have two internship courses: (This does not apply to Mitacs fellows. Mitacs fellows need to follow step 4 for project reports.) You know who you are by looking at the spreadsheet. Typically, you would have replaced one or two of the regular courses, with one or two project courses. Your project reports are simpler. They are in lieu of a regular course, so require 100 hours of technical work and 20 hours of report writing. If the project is extracted from your internship, the internship needs to be eight months. Your logs should explicitly state how many hours were taken out of the internship, so we know that you are not double counting the efforts. For two such project courses, please double the hours. I will be the only one reviewing such reports.

7. Timelines for project reports:

We are developing a Brightspace based report submission and evaluation system. The timelines mentioned below will be enforced through the system, which includes a limit on number of drafts that you are able to submit. Please take utmost care with the preparation of each draft with the help of Grammarly and writing center. You can also use ChatGPT as a productivity enhancement tool. You should mention how you used each of these tools in a cover letter. **If you exceed the maximum number of drafts, your evaluation will be delayed to the end of the term or beyond possibly resulting in missing the January convocation deadline.**

Kannagi Mahajan will provide you support for report writing. She will be hosting seminars in June to help you get started. The seminars will be recorded, and you are strongly encouraged to refer to them as you write your reports. All the communications with her will be through the Brightspace portal for report writing.

First project course: All the project reports must be with your supervisors no later than **August 1**. I must get a copy of the report approved by your supervisor by December 15th. We will not be doing a committee review until the second project report is submitted.

Second project course: All the project reports must be with your supervisors no later than **November 1**. You have to respond quickly to the supervisor comments, so that the reports reach the examining committee by **November 15th**. If the reports are written well, it will take two weeks for the rest of the approval process. This will allow me to submit your grades by early **December**.

8. Timelines for internship reports:

We are developing a Brightspace based report submission and evaluation system. The timelines mentioned below will be enforced through the system, which includes a limit on number of drafts that you are able to submit. Please take utmost care with the preparation of each draft with the help of Grammarly and writing center. You can also use ChatGPT as a productivity enhancement tool. You should mention how you used each of these tools in a cover letter. **If you exceed the maximum number of drafts, your evaluation will be delayed to the end of the term or beyond possibly resulting in missing the January convocation deadline.**

Kannagi Mahajan will provide you support for report writing. She will be hosting seminars in June to help you get started. The seminars will be recorded, and you are strongly encouraged to refer to them as you write your reports. All the communications with her will be through the Brightspace portal for report writing.

First internship course: If you are continuing with the same employer for the second internship course, you only need to send me a draft of the report by **August 15th**. If you are NOT continuing with the same employer for the second internship course, **you need to send me a draft of the report by August 1st and final report with the approval of your industry supervisor by August 15th.**

Second internship course: All the internship reports with the approval of your industry supervisor should reach me by **November 22nd**. This will allow me to submit your grades by early **December**.

9. Graduation process: Please make sure that you have cleared all your dues (however, small). If there is a hold on your account, I will not be able to proceed. Once I have submitted all your grades, I will ask the registrar's office to conduct a degree audit. I send a mail to registrar every Thursday with the list of students. In order to make it to the Thursday mail, your report must be approved by everyone including me by Tuesday. After Associate Registrar has processed your audit, you will receive a completion e-mail. You can ONLY order your potential graduate letter after you receive the completion e-mail. If you send a request prior to receiving the completion letter, it has no effect and will be ignored (you will have to resend the request again when you receive the completion e-mail). Once you have obtained the letter, please send it to me. I will then send you a supplemental letter describing the program structure. These two letters should be used to apply for the postgraduate work permit (PGWP).

I have received some information from students who are applying for PGWP that I am passing on to you as received. Please make sure that you do not work between the time you receive your potential graduate letter and application for PGWP. Once you receive a message such as what you see below, you should be able to start working under PGWP. This is not advice from me, just what recent students have told me.

This confirms that your application has been received by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) on (yyyy/mm/dd).

Please attach this letter to your present Study permit Number as proof that you are authorized to work for any employer, in any occupation with no restriction on hours until or until a decision is made on your application, whichever is first.

This period of work is authorized as per subsection 186(w) of the Immigration and Refugees Protection Regulations.



I have no control over the timelines within the university. Typically, I will submit your grades within 24 to 48 hours as long as the reports are approved as indicated earlier. Experience suggests that the Associate Registrar and their support staff will need another week to ten days. So it is fair to assume that from the approval of the reports, it will take two weeks for you to apply for PGWP. However, travel and unforeseen circumstances may delay the process.

10. Work authorization after submitting a post-graduation work permit application

I am not qualified to give you advice on immigration matters. The following is an excerpt from:

<https://www.canada.ca/en/immigration-refugees-citizenship/corporate/publications-manuals/operational-bulletins-manuals/temporary-residents/study-permits/post-graduation-work-permit-program/permit.html>

Per [paragraph R186\(w\)](#), graduates who apply for a work permit, such as a post-graduation work permit, **before the expiry of their study permit** are eligible to work full time without a work permit while waiting for a decision on their application if all of the following apply:

- They are or were the holders of a valid study permit at the time of the post-graduation work permit application.
- They have completed their program of study.
- They met the requirements for working off campus without a work permit under paragraph R186(v) (that is, they were a full-time student enrolled at a DLI in a post-secondary academic, vocational or professional training program of at least 6 months in duration that led to a degree, diploma or certificate).
- They did not exceed the allowable hours of work under paragraph R186(v).

Applicants must stop working as soon as they are notified by IRCC (for example, via their MyAccount, by email or by mailed letter) that their application for a work permit is refused.

The actual wording of 186, 186(w), and 186(v) referred earlier can be seen at:

<https://laws-lois.justice.gc.ca/eng/regulations/sor-2002-227/section-186.html>

11. Travel delays: I will try to respond to all the important messages within 24-48 hours. More importantly, the registrar office gets very busy in **December**. If your reports are not approved by **December 1st**, be prepared to postpone your graduation to **May**. This does not affect your ability to apply for PGWP and take up a job (please see the previous information about graduation process).

Thank you and we look forward to working with you to help you wrap up this final phase of your journey through M.Sc. CDA.

I have added two more pages that relate to various misunderstandings that I have come across this year. Please keep on reading.

First some words of comfort:

I am a strong supporter of your career aspirations after graduation and have always managed to come up with a solution that facilitates your transition to a full-time employment.

Now words of caution:

1. Your graduation date is in **January**. I am told that I am the only Director of a non-thesis graduate program that asks registrar to process your degree audits in the middle of a semester. They reorganize their workflow to accommodate these requests. Any processing of grades and graduation paperwork is done as a goodwill. It is not your right to demand expeditious processing of your graduation paperwork.
2. I am expected to submit all the grades in the first week of December, if all the academic requirements are complete to my satisfaction. The absolute deadline for January graduation is first week of January. If your academic performance is not satisfactory by that date, your graduation will be postponed by one semester.
3. Academic requirements do not mean:
 - a. spending 600 hours in front of a computer and dabble in report writing for another 120 hours for two project courses or
 - b. spending six months with a company and submitting a report for two internship courses
4. The hours (for project courses) and months (for internship courses) are the minimum requirements. You must prove that you have done a completely satisfactory job both technically and professionally. Your industry and academic supervisors, report readers, report writing mentors, project management instructors must be completely satisfied. All the contractual obligations that you agreed to must be satisfied before your grades will be submitted.
5. With the above disclaimers, I want to reiterate that we have processed grades and graduation paperwork of more than 150 students to help them transition to postgraduate work in a timely manner usually in the middle of the fourth semester.

Some principles that you should be aware of:

I had unpleasant experience with a couple of students from January 2021 cohort that included immigration counselors from student services and the Dean of FGSR. I want to describe the principles that you should follow:

1. You cease to be a student and cannot work using the internship work permit:
 - a. After formal convocation
 - b. after receiving potential graduate letter (please read "Graduation process" on earlier pages)

Those are the only two triggers that terminate your student status.

2. (Reiterating earlier information) Once you cease to be a student through two triggers described above, you are eligible to apply for PGWP. I have recently received some information from students who are applying for PGWP that I am passing on to you as received. Please make sure that you do not work between the time you receive your potential graduate letter and application for PGWP. Once you receive a message such as what you see below, you should be able to start working under PGWP. This is not advice from me, just what recent students have told me.
This confirms that your application has been received by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) on [REDACTED] (yyyy/mm/dd).

Please attach this letter to your present Study permit Number [REDACTED] as proof that you are authorized to work for any employer, in any occupation with no restriction on hours until [REDACTED] or until a decision is made on your application, whichever is first.

This period of work is authorized as per subsection 186(w) of the Immigration and Refugees Protection Regulations.



3. There were some wrongful claims that if professors submit all your outstanding grades in a semester, you are no longer a student. It is not true. As long as you have registered in FGSR9000 (mandatory), you will be a student until the end of the semester unless you ask for and receive a potential graduate letter. However, if you do not want me to submit your grades prior to December first week deadline, I will humor you. You can send me an email saying that your grade should not be submitted before December 15th. I will hold off your grade until December 15th and submit it as soon

thereafter as possible. Converse is not true – you cannot ask me to submit a grade before a certain date. I will not submit your grade until the conditions described in “Now words of caution” are satisfied and I am able to process all the information. As a responsible faculty member, I always try to meet the first week of December deadline or as soon thereafter as possible. However, there are no guarantees.

4. You cannot work for more than eight months on internship work permit.
5. You cannot ask for potential graduate letter before the beginning of the fourth semester.
6. Mitacs fellowship does not need internship work permit for several reasons:
 - a. It is a scholarship not a paid work.
 - b. Your work is divided into two parts: university component and company component. At no time, you work for more than 20 hours on the company component.

If you do not have a good understanding of the principles outlined above, you should not take up an industry related project or an external internship nor apply for potential graduate letter prior to convocation.

If you consult anyone else and they give a contrary advice, and you believe that they understand:

- your situation
- academic regulations
- immigration law

please feel free to follow their advice. My recent experiences suggest that some of the conflicting advice was due to lack of understanding of one or more of the three aspects mentioned above. I will not take part in any discussions on these matters after your receiving contrary advice from someone else. I am your Professor and Director of the program. My only responsibility is to provide reasonable academic support and ensure academic integrity throughout your tenure as a student.